



Standing Committee on Planning, Development and Special Initiatives meets

PLANNING COMMITTEE VOICES SERIOUS CONCERNS OVER DELAYS IN RS. 465 BILLION LAHORE–BAHAWALNAGAR MOTORWAY PROJECT, SEEKS DETAILED REPORT

Islamabad, 7 April 2026: The 14th meeting of the Standing Committee on Planning, Development and Special Initiatives was held at Parliament House, Islamabad, under the chairmanship of Syed Abdul Kadir Gillani, MNA.

The Committee took up the Calling Attention Notice moved by Syed Naveed Qamar, MNA, regarding the Federal Government's takeover of the Rs. 465 billion Lahore–Bahawalnagar Motorway Project, including concerns about alleged violations of federal fiscal priorities and the diversion of resources from nationally strategic development projects.

The Ministry concerned briefed the Committee on the current status of the project, including completion timelines and financing arrangements in place. Members expressed reservations regarding the viability of the Public-Private Partnership (PPP) model and the feasibility of achieving project targets in the prevailing economic conditions marked by fiscal constraints and inflation.



Islamabad 07.04.2026: Chairman Standing Committee on Planning Development & Special Initiatives Syed Abdul Kadir Gilani chairing the committee meeting at Parliament House.

The Committee also reviewed the status of the N-5 National Highway, which remains incomplete to date. The Ministry informed the Committee that the delay is primarily due to ongoing litigation. The Committee directed the Ministry to submit a comprehensive report on the matter. Moreover, the need for special development projects in Dera Ismail Khan was emphasised, noting that large-scale infrastructure initiatives cannot be effectively undertaken by provincial governments alone. The Committee agreed to consider proposals presented by the representatives concerned for urgent development interventions in the region.

The Committee also deliberated on challenges in the implementation of development projects across different regions, highlighting inconsistencies in administrative and financial criteria. The Committee expressed dissatisfaction with the briefing and decided that sub-committees shall be formed to examine issues related to the Lahore–Bahawalnagar Motorway Project, as well as delays in the completion of projects undertaken by the Pakistan Infrastructure Development Company Limited (PIDCL). The Committee further decided that a verification visit to IFRAP-related infrastructure projects in Balochistan shall be conducted and findings submitted for further action.

During the discussion on a starred question raised by Ms. Shazia Sobia Aslam Soomro, MNA, concerns were expressed regarding discrepancies between reported progress in education and health initiatives and findings reflected in recent international assessments, including reports by UNICEF. She questioned the effectiveness of ongoing interventions and the utilisation of allocated funds.



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Questions were also raised regarding the effectiveness of development spending in Punjab despite substantial allocations. It was clarified that education and health are provincial subjects following constitutional devolution. The Ministry further informed the Committee that the overall development fund volume has, in real terms, effectively contracted due to inflation and fiscal pressures. At the same time, provincial PSDP allocations have increased, and members were advised to raise questions regarding utilisation and outcomes with the respective provincial authorities. The Committee also considered the suggestion to utilise Sustainable Development Goals (SDG) forums within national and provincial legislatures to strengthen oversight and coordination.

The Committee raised no reservations regarding the PSDP budgetary proposals of the Ministry of Planning, Development and Special Initiatives for the next fiscal year. However, consideration of the remaining agenda items, including the “Public Private Partnership Authority (Amendment) Bill, 2025” and the “General Statistics (Reorganization) (Amendment) Bill, 2025,” was deferred to a future meeting.

The meeting was attended by Syed Sami Ul Hassan Gillani, MNA; Ms. Naz Baloch, MNA; Ms. Akhtar Bibi, MNA; and Major (R) Tahir Iqbal, MNA. Participation via video link was made by Ms. Izbal Zehri, MNA, and Mr. Zulfiqar Bachani, MNA. The movers of the Calling Attention Notice, Syed Naveed Qamar, MNA, and Ms. Shazia Sobia Aslam Soomro, MNA, were also present. Special invitees included Syed Ali Haider Gillani, MPA; Malik Muhammad Arshad, MPA; and Mr. Fateh Ullah Khan, MNA, along with representatives from relevant ministries and departments.

Nazish Tariq
Secretary Committee